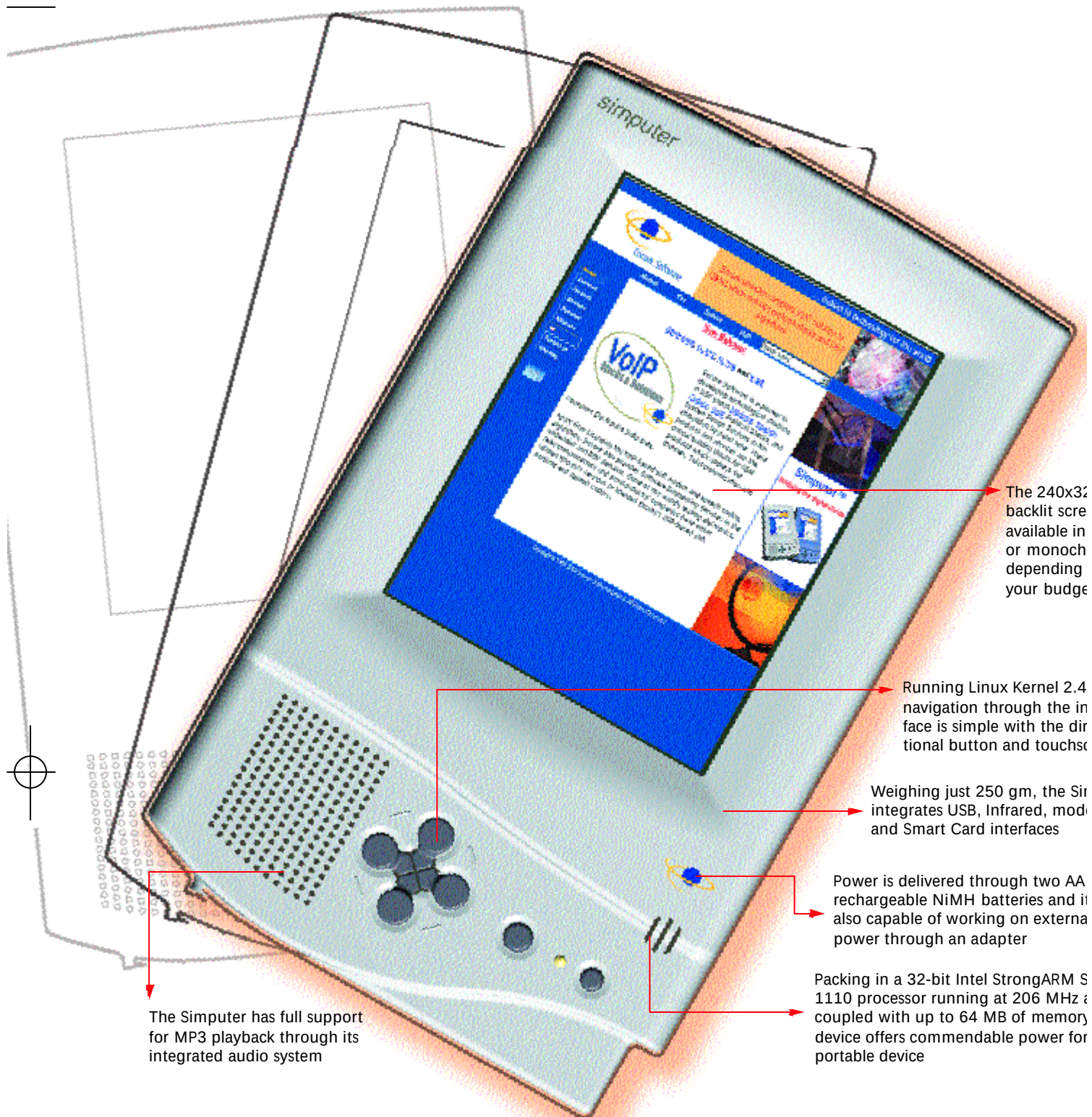




The Simputer runs GNU/Linux operating systems, which coupled with the Perl scripting environment means that applications can be easily written for it. The software has been created keeping the application development cycles in mind, so that the whole process can be worked out quickly and economically. Being an open source platform, it is relatively easy and quick to develop application-specific tasks. The device also features a Web browser, an e-mail client and a host of other applications that further enhance its functionality, especially in rural areas.

One of the most impressive integrated

applications is one called Dhvani, a text-to-speech tool that generates intelligible speech from a phonetic description in virtually any Indian language. It can also convert any UTF-8 text in Hindi or Kannada to this phonetic description and then speak it out with the integrated Phonetics-to-Speech engine. PicoPeta, the developers of the Simputer, claim that given their developmental tools, they can develop front ends for any other language, even non-Indian ones.

The application interface used by the Simputer is based on a variant of the already popular and universally accepted

XML. Known as IML (Inform Markup Language), its main aim is to provide a consistent and lucid front end for all users—even those who are illiterate. It uses simple icons and the text-to-speech engine and can communicate with users in their local language. Therefore, the Simputer, a simple and uniform interface is presented for running applications.

One of the most critical device features ensures that the Simputer can be used for a variety of applications is the Smart Card reader. The Smart Card makes the Simputer safe for all kinds of transactions, even for financial and banking purposes. It